

Quiz #1 (100 points): Present your answer in a matrix form on ethical theories as to its definition and present scenario/example where you can explain the specific ethical theory (example shall be correlated to “Information Technology”)

Ethical Theory	Definition	Example
Utilitarianism	Utilitarianism is a consequentialist ethical theory primarily developed by Jeremy Bentham and John Stuart Mill. It states that the moral worth of an action is determined entirely by its outcomes or consequences. The central guiding rule is the Greatest Happiness Principle: an action is morally right if it produces the greatest amount of net happiness, utility, or well-being for the greatest number of people, while minimizing overall harm.	Network Traffic Prioritization during a Public Emergency: A major telecommunications provider experiencing severe infrastructure congestion following a natural disaster. An IT team must configure the network's Quality of Service (QoS) algorithms. Under a Utilitarian framework, the team optimizes bandwidth allocation to prioritize emergency response systems, local hospitals, and crisis messaging over non-essential video streaming services. Although high-definition entertainment streams are temporarily throttled for ordinary consumers, this decision produces the greatest net utility by enabling life-saving emergency communications for the majority of the community.
Deontology (Duty Based Ethics)	Deontology, championed by Immanuel Kant, focuses on inherent duty, moral rules, and principles rather than consequences. It holds that certain actions are intrinsically right or wrong regardless of their outcomes. Deontology emphasizes universal moral laws (such as "do not lie" or "do not steal") and stresses that ethical choices must be guided by duty and proper moral intention.	Refusing to Build a Privacy-Violating Backdoor: Suppose a lead software engineer is ordered by company executives to create a hidden "backdoor" in an encrypted messaging application to help the marketing department harvest user data without explicit consent. The executives argue that this will significantly boost company profits and prevent layoffs. A deontological developer will refuse to write the code because invading user privacy and breaching trust violates fundamental moral duties and data privacy rules—regardless of the financial benefits or negative consequences to their personal job security.

Virtue Ethics	Rooted in ancient Greek philosophy, most notably Aristotle, Virtue Ethics shifts the focus from actions or rules to the moral character of the individual. Instead of asking "<i>What rule should I follow?</i>", Virtue Ethics asks "<i>What kind of person should I be?</i>" It highlights the development of virtues (such as honesty, courage, responsibility, and justice) through practice, aiming for the Golden Mean—the healthy balance between extremes of deficiency and excess.	Responsible Cybersecurity Vulnerability Disclosure Consider an ethical hacker who discovers a critical security vulnerability in a widely used web framework. An individual acting with virtue demonstrates integrity and prudence. Rather than exploiting the bug for personal gain (recklessness/greed) or ignoring it completely (negligence), they practice <i>responsible disclosure</i>: quietly notifying the software developers, giving them reasonable time to issue a patch, and maintaining open, honest communication with the open-source community.
Rights Theory	Rights Theory asserts that individuals possess inherent human rights (such as life, liberty, and privacy) that impose correlative duties on others to respect and protect those claims. An action is considered morally wrong if it violates or infringes upon an individual's fundamental rights.	Granular Data Consent and Compliance: Consider an e-commerce platform updating its user database. Under Rights-Based Ethics, individual users possess an inherent right to informational privacy and control over their personal data. To uphold this right, IT architects design explicit opt-in privacy controls in compliance with regulations like the EU's General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). The system prohibits selling user browsing histories to third-party brokers without explicit, informed consent.
Justice and Fairness Theory	Grounded in political philosophy—most prominently John Rawls' theory of <i>Justice as Fairness</i>—this theory emphasizes impartiality, equity, and fair distribution of benefits and burdens across society. Rawls proposed evaluating social frameworks behind a "<i>veil of ignorance</i>," where decisions are made without knowing one's own social status, race, or abilities, ensuring that systems treat equals equally and actively protect the least advantaged.	Auditing Algorithmic Bias in Automated Hiring Systems: A tech enterprise deploys an AI tool to filter thousands of candidate resumes. During internal audits, data scientists discover that historical training data caused the algorithm to systematically penalize applications from female candidates. Guided by Justice and Fairness Theory, the organization suspends the system to retrain the model, removing biased variables to ensure equal opportunity and fair evaluation for all applicants, regardless of demographic background.
Ethical Relativism	Ethical Relativism is the view that moral standards and principles are	Global Content Moderation and Jurisdiction Handling:

	not absolute or universally applicable, but are relative to specific cultural norms, societal traditions, or legal jurisdictions. What is deemed ethical or acceptable in one context or country may be viewed differently in another.	Consider a global social media platform operating across multiple continents. In Germany, strict federal regulations require technology platforms to quickly remove hate speech and neo-Nazi content. Conversely, in the United States, free expression protections under the First Amendment permit a significantly broader scope of speech online. Under Ethical Relativism, the platform's trust and safety engineering team tailors automated content moderation protocols to respect local legal and cultural norms rather than forcing a single, blanket standard worldwide.
Social Contract Theory	Developed by political theorists such as Thomas Hobbes, John Locke, and Jean-Jacques Rousseau, Social Contract Theory posits that individuals implicitly consent to surrender certain personal freedoms to an authority or community in exchange for security, order, and mutual benefits. Moral and social obligations depend on this mutually agreed-upon contract.	Corporate Acceptable Use Policies (AUP) and Security Protocols: When employees join a modern software company, they sign an Acceptable Use Policy (AUP) and agree to abide by cybersecurity protocols—such as multi-factor authentication (MFA) and restriction from downloading unauthorized software. In this digital social contract, employees surrender a degree of personal digital freedom on work devices; in return, the organization provides a secure digital workspace, protects employee records, and safeguards collective assets against cyberattacks.

References used:

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<https://www.scribd.com/document/854363552/Ethical-Theories-in-IT>

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